

SOCIO-ECONOMIC IMPACTS OF BUDDHIST TOURISM ON REGIONAL DEVELOPMENT IN SARNATH AND KUSHINAGAR IN POST-LIBERALISATION INDIA (1991-PRESENT)

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INTRODUCTION

The advent of economic liberalisation in India in 1991 marked a paradigm shift in the country's development trajectory. Liberalisation not only reoriented national economic policies towards market-driven growth but also stimulated the growth of tourism as a significant economic sector. Among various tourism forms, religious and heritage tourism has gained remarkable prominence, particularly in regions associated with India's ancient cultural and spiritual history. Buddhist tourism, centred on key historical sites such as Sarnath and Kushinagar, has been a significant beneficiary of this transformation.

Sarnath, near Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh, is recognised globally as the site where Gautama Buddha delivered his first sermon. Kushinagar, situated in eastern Uttar Pradesh, is revered as the site of the Buddha's Mahaparinirvana (final nirvana). Both sites have been central to Buddhist sacred geography since the early centuries of the Common Era. However, after a long period of relative historical obscurity, these sites underwent a rediscovery and heritage revalorisation, particularly during colonial archaeological interventions and post-independence heritage policies.

The era since 1991 has witnessed an intensification of domestic and international Buddhist pilgrimage and tourism, facilitated by improved infrastructure, state and central tourism policies, and global interest from Buddhist-majority countries such as Japan, Thailand, Sri Lanka, and Myanmar. These developments have transformed both Sarnath and Kushinagar into significant nodes within the state-initiated Buddhist Circuit, aimed at promoting cultural tourism and enhancing regional economies.

Despite considerable attention to the religious and spiritual significance of these sites, systematic research on the socio-economic impacts of Buddhist tourism in these regions remains limited. Questions remain about how tourism has affected local employment, income patterns, infrastructure development, urban transformation, and social structures among communities intimately involved with heritage and pilgrimage economies. There is also a need

to assess disparities, challenges, and unintended consequences of tourism-led development, particularly in rural or peri-urban environments.

This research proposes to fill that gap by conducting a comparative, historical, and socio-economic analysis of Buddhist tourism's impact on regional development in the Sarnath and Kushinagar zones in the post-liberalisation era (1991–present). The study will explore how tourism has reshaped local economies, transformed livelihoods, and interacted with broader regional planning efforts under frameworks such as the Buddhist Circuit and the National Tourism Policy.

STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

While Buddhist tourism is widely acknowledged for its cultural and spiritual value, its socio-economic implications for host regions have not been sufficiently historicised or empirically analysed in the Indian context. There is a lack of comparative data on how Sarnath and Kushinagar, two historically significant but socio-economically distinct contexts, have experienced and managed tourism-driven development in the era following India's economic liberalisation. This study addresses that gap by investigating:

- The nature and extent of socio-economic change linked to Buddhist tourism
- The role of public and private stakeholders in facilitating or mediating these changes
- Variations in development outcomes between Sarnath and Kushinagar

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

- To examine changes in socio-economic indicators (employment, income distribution, infrastructure) in Sarnath and Kushinagar since 1991.
- To assess the contribution of Buddhist tourism to regional development in both sites.
- To analyse state policies, institutional frameworks, and private-sector influences on tourism growth.
- To compare and contrast developmental trajectories in Sarnath and Kushinagar in terms of economic outcomes, social change, and spatial reorganisation.
- To document perceptions and experiences of local communities regarding tourism-driven socio-economic change.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- What socio-economic changes have occurred in Sarnath and Kushinagar since 1991, and to what extent are these associated with Buddhist tourism?
- How have local economies transformed in terms of employment patterns, income sources, and business activities?
- What has been the role of government policies and tourism infrastructure investments in shaping regional development?
- Are there observable differences in socio-economic impacts between Sarnath and Kushinagar? If so, what explains these differences?
- How do residents, business actors, and stakeholders perceive the benefits and challenges of tourism-led development?

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

The study will draw on:

- Tourism-led development theory (role of tourism as an engine of regional growth)
- Heritage economy concept (heritage as a resource for economic production)
- Political economy of development (state, market, and community interactions)
- Social impact theory (effects of tourism on community structure and identity)

METHODOLOGY

Research Design

A comparative, mixed-methods research design will be adopted.

Data Collection

A. Quantitative Methods

- Analysis of census data (1991, 2001, 2011, 2021)
- Tourism statistics (arrival data, expenditure patterns)
- Local economic data (informal sector surveys, employment figures)

B. Qualitative Methods

- Semi-structured interviews with:
- Local residents
- Business owners (hotels, guides, vendors)
- Tourism officials
- Representatives of Buddhist institutions
- Focus group discussions among community members
- Participant observation at key tourism sites

Data Sources

- Government reports (Ministry of Tourism, UP Tourism)
- Development plans and policy documents
- Census of India records
- Local economic surveys
- Primary field data

SCOPE AND DELIMITATIONS

Spatial Scope: Sarnath (Varanasi district) and Kushinagar (Kushinagar district), Uttar Pradesh.

Temporal Scope: 1991–present.

Delimitations: The study will not undertake an exhaustive anthropological study of religious practices but will focus on socio-economic changes linked to tourism.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY

This research contributes to:

- A deeper understanding of tourism as a catalyst for regional development
- Policy debates on tourism planning and community welfare
- Heritage studies that integrate economic and social impacts
- Scholarship on post-liberalisation transformations in India

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

The study is expected to:

- Provide empirically grounded insights into tourism's contribution to livelihoods
- Identify differential growth patterns between the two regions
- Offer policy recommendations for sustainable tourism development
- Contribute to theory-building on heritage economies

TENTATIVE CHAPTERISATION

1. Introduction & Context
2. Literature Review & Theoretical Framework
3. Methodology
4. Tourism Development and Economic Change in Sarnath
5. Tourism Development and Socio-Economic Outcomes in Kushinagar
6. Comparative Analysis
7. Conclusion & Policy Implications